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Pond in Semmancheri to be restored

Two water bodies in Chennai will get a new lease of life thanks to CSR support from AU Small Finance Bank. To mark World Water Day, the bank announced funds to undertaken lake and pond rejuvenation initiatives at Medavakkam Lake and Pazhathotta Pond in Semmancheri.

At Medavakkam Lake, a 199.1-acre urban lake with a 144.1-acre water spread, AU SFB will undertake desilting, waste removal, invasive vegetation management, development of a blue-green ecological buffer and fencing of vulnerable stretches to prevent encroachment, improving ecological integrity and long-term water storage potential, said a release.

Work at the two-acre Pazhathotta Pond in Semmancheri along the OMR corridor will involve desilting, embankment strengthening, inlet-outlet regulation, native species plantation, biodiversity enhancement measures, and protective fencing to stabilise the pond and its surrounding ecosystem.

These interventions aim to significantly improve groundwater recharge, enhance flood moderation, and rebuild ecological balance in fast-developing and climate-sensitive micro-catchments, contributing to a more resilient urban water system for Chennai, added the release.

The AU Green Project remains a key pillar of the Bank's FY 2025-26 vision, with a strong focus on water conservation, ecosystem restoration, and local climate adaptation in alignment with India's broader sustainability priorities.

Gandhi Nagar resident's latest book, a collection of stories

The Greatest Sweepstake, a collection of 22 stories (for the young and the ever young), was recently self-published by Hema Ravi. An educator, writer, poet, freelance language trainer and independent researcher, Hema is based out of Chennai.

The stories cover a wide range of themes, from childhood wonder and fantasy to real-life issues such as injustice, identity struggles and hardship. Varying in length, these narratives are rich in emotion and meaning, says a press release.



Hema has also authored *Joie De Vivre* (a collection of poems), *The Cuckoo Sings Again* (collection of short stories) and *Everyday English* (self-tutor).

For copies of *The Greatest Sweepstake*, contact Hema Ravi at 9841003201 or email her at hemaravi24@gmail.com

Annual sale at Sundari Silks

Sundari Silks in Adyar is back with its annual sale. From classic silk saris, 'Athirsham' silver jewellery, 'Navira' women's wear, 'Naran' menswear, kids' wear, hand-crafted essentials to home decors, there's a lot to choose during the sale, said a press release.

A discount of 50 percent is also being offered. The sale is on till April 5. For details, contact 9176422993.

A skill that bloomed afresh during the pandemic

From origami classes at Rosary matriculation school to the two-day Makers Market in Mylapore now, Adyar resident Priya Subramaniam has come a long way. She would be showcasing her paper flowers at the event, which concludes today



and started attempting them. It took me a while to learn different techniques of colouring paper, stretching and moulding it to resemble real petals. Books on paper flower making and online video tutorials helped refine my process," says Priya.

The pandemic had a markedly clear silver lining for her; paper flower making would soon graduate from being an interest and hobby horse into an enterprise.

She has discovered a hugely responsive marketplace in Instagram.

"Instagram has opened me to a world of amazing artists and

helps put my work out there and get feedback and appreciation," she elaborates.

Exhibitions

In the online world, artists are not constrained by geography, their works being transported to the nooks and crannies of the world, but still, there is a majesty about displaying one's works in a physical space for eyes to see and appreciate. Priya wanted that experience for her, and that came her way. "Fuelled by positive response to my posts on Instagram, I participated in an event by Flair street events, showing my work along with other artists," says Priya.

And she in the midst of another opportunity. Paper flowers made by her are at display at Makers Market (March 22 is the concluding day) in Mylapore, organised by "By Hand From The Heart".

Priya's Insta handle is @paperflowersbypriya



The pandemic has been an inflexion point for many, giving them the mental space to revive old passions, sometimes dusting off an old hobby or rejuvenating an old skill that had all but atrophied.

Adyar Priya Subramaniam can relate to that. For her, a fascination for paper crafts began with an exposure to origami at school, Rosary Matriculation School in Santhome. She was sold on the idea of creating snowflakes and flowers with nothing but paper. She would turn her hand at paper quilling and paper cutting, but that was about it, the interest and aptitude were stunted, not reaching its potential, until the pandemic happened, when it bloomed afresh and big. It has only gotten bigger since then. "The pandemic happened and I chanced upon the world of paper flowers. These were more realistic and lifelike than the ones I had made before. I came across Youtube videos

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Handling waste without protective gear

In the outskirts of Chennai such as Kelambakkam and Padur, one can encounter people rummaging through waste without wearing protective gear

Shanthi, a resident of Uthiramerur, was born with Congenital Transverse Deficiency that has caused her to have one ill-formed hand, her left hand no more than an unhelpful stump.

Shanthi works in the OMR region as cutter and gatherer of wood. She also looks for copper wires in garbage heaps when she can take time out of her day job..

She is seen here at a garbage pile-up on Padur Bypass Road, on March 20, 2026.

Only moments earlier she was picking up electrical wires for their copper. Shanthi represents a group of part-time workers in the informal recyclable waste ecosystem, workers more informal than the regular informal work force, and they in the least aware of the potential hazards of handling certain forms of waste, leave alone being worried about that. Even those working in the known informal waste collection informal sector, particularly in the outlying regions of Chennai, such as Kelambakkam, those picking discards for a living do not pay attention to their personal safety while rummaging through waste.



Shanthi, a resident of Uthiramerur, at Padur Bypass Road. PHOTO: PRINCE FREDERICK

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‘Reed’ it right: **bulrushes support avain families**

The Clamorous reed warbler is as loud as they come, but in the urban environment, it is outshouted. Weed clearing at urban habitats in Chennai often brings down its home, the bulrushes. Bulrushes in wetlands are not encroachments, but ‘legal homes’ to birds in the crane and rail family and warblers, so government line agencies ought to tread on them thoughtfully



Across India, the Clamorous reed warbler is common, but its signature clamour gets drowned in urban habitats.
PHOTO: PRINCE FREDERICK

PRINCE FREDERICK

If there is an unabashedly explicit and comprehensively explanatory name under the sun, it is “Clamorous reed warbler”. It encapsulates the species’ social behaviour (trying to shout down everything it encounters within earshot) and habitat preference (reeds, specifically bulrushes). Even its binomial name, *Acrocephalus stentoreus* underlines its boundless capacity for stentorian cries.

In habitats within Chennai limits, its shouting matches might be on a lower key, “foreign powers” making it an unequal contest. Motor vehicles “talk” over the Clamorous reed warbler, the steady hum of running engines drowning its throaty, grating, loud calls. Infrastructure works bring their own din. The Clamorous reed warbler might also find

The crane and rail story

At the slightest suspicion of being noticed, cranes steal away into the bulrushes, the Red-breasted crane more swiftly than the others. The Baillon’s crane could be slightly more tolerant of unwanted attention, but would still stay as close to the reeds as possible while foraging for food. At a reedy patch in Karapakkam right outside a bund of the Pallikaranai Marsh, the Baillon’s crane and the Red-breasted crane would be sighted regularly, and in the nano second in which they would let their guard down, birders would photograph them. That patch has been on a downward course ever since Greater Chen-



The Baillon’s crane needs the ‘safety’ of bulrushes. Photo: Prince Frederick

nai Corporation constructed stormwater drains in the streets leading to it. As part of the SWD construction, massive old concrete pipes were gouged out. Huge boulders which are debris occupy just the section where

its ranks dwindling in urban habitats with loss of reed beds made up of bulrushes. In many parts of the Indian subcontinent, resident populations of the Clamorous reed warbler can be found. In some parts, it is a mix of resident and migratory populations.

If one wants to find the Clamorous reed warbler living up to its name and clamour hard for attention and be heard loud and clear, one has to head to landscapes untouched by development, essentially patches with an overpowering pastoral character. One such patch this writer can recommend lies in Kancheepuram district. To underline how far from Chennai one has to stray to listen to this bird in its unfettered voice at this patch, it is a lake flung around 60 kilometres far away from Chennai’s Pallikaranai marsh, in Kancheepuram district on a link road between

In some instances, bulrushes might have to be sacrificed, but there would also be instances where they could be protected; and they should be protected in those circumstances

Enathur (near the doorway of the temple city Kancheepuram) and Rajakulam (where NH48 has a run). This lake has been christened Sitimabakkam lake by some locals, and others have other names for it. This lake’s buffer zone is pockmarked with patches of water. These patches sport shocks of bulrushes where this bird’s clamour rises to the skies, uninterrupted by ambient sounds. Being found in good numbers at this patch, the Clamorous reed warbler fills the space with its calls, somewhat like a symphony orchestra filling a hall, only that the sounds are grating and raucous.

Beds of bulrushes support waterbirds in the crane and rail family and warblers such as Pallas’s grasshopper warbler and the Clamorous reed warbler.

Urban habitats in Chennai

Returning to Chennai, de-silting and weed removal works in these habitats, particularly carried out in anticipation of the north-east monsoon disturb, unsettle and even obliterate bulrushes. These works are carried out by the Water Resources Department and in instances where lakes are managed by it, Greater Chennai Corporation. Given their mandate and responsibilities, these line agencies would be focussed on ensuring free flow of water, more than anything else. They need to be schooled that everything coming across as weeds need not be weeds; they could be important cogs in the wheel driving ecological balance.

At least in Pallikaranai and Perumbakkam and similar urban habitats that are subject to frequent improvements, the forest department, which has stakes in them, should educate WRD that earth movers need to be wielded with the finesse of a doctor using a scalpel. While removing water hyacinth (which needs to go, considering how they interfere with water flow), care should be taken to retain bulrushes. In some instances, bulrushes might have to be sacrificed, but there would also be instances where they could be protected; and they should be protected in those circumstances.

Workshop on wedding photography

Entrepreneurship Development & Innovation Institute, a Department of MSME - Tamil Nadu is conducting a training programme on wedding photography and video editing from March 23 to 27. For details, call 8668102600/8754495254.

Making incense sticks

The institute is also conducting another workshop on making incense sticks, camphor, and candles from March 24 to 26. The session will also focus on making rose water and detergents meant for cleaning brass and silver articles. Both liquid and power detergents will be taught, says a press release. For details, call 9360221280 / 98401 14680.

Both the workshops will be held at the institute's premises at EDII Office Road, Ekkattuthangal. Time: From 10 a.m. to 5 p.m. Prior registration is mandatory. Those 18 years of age and above can take part.

Valedictory ceremony at Stella Maris College held



Stella Maris College hosted its ceremonial and traditional valedictory ceremony on March 18, marking the end of the academic journey of its final-year students. The programme began with a traditional lighting of the lamp, followed by a multi-faith prayer service with readings from the Holy Bible, Gitanjali, and the holy Quran, reflecting the institution's inclusive ethos, said a release. The western music club of the college rendered hymns that set a solemn tone for the evening.

The event was graced by chief guest Ramya Kannan, Health Editor and Chief of Bureau, *The Hindu*, Tamil Nadu, and an alumna of the college. Principal Sr. Stella Mary, and secretary Sr. Judith Anita Gonsalvaz felicitated the chief guest with a memento and a flower pot. In her address, Ramya Kannan motivated and inspired the students with her reflections on the importance

of women to take care of themselves, personal grit and resilience, and heightened social responsibility. She added "Every monsoon we fall down and every monsoon we rise back," thereby encouraging the students to be bold achievers who persevere through challenges.

Nalini Raj, coordinator of The Alumnae Association of Stella Maris College (AASMC) presented the annual report, which was followed by a video showcasing the alumnae association activities and initiatives over the years. The annual newsletter of AASMC was unveiled by the principal, and the other dignitaries, marking another milestone and the institution's ongoing engagement with alumni.

Students from various departments shared their reflections on their academic journey highlighting growth, friendship, and learning experiences at the college.

Foreign language classes

Chinese and Japanese language classes are held at Malavia Avenue, Thiruvanniyur. The classes are intensive programs designed for students, professionals, travelers, and hobbyists at affordable prices and convenient schedules. The beginner's courses are essential for learners to pass the Japanese Language Proficiency Test (N5) and the Hanyu Shuiping Kaoshi (Level 1) exams in Japanese and Chinese. For details, call 9280205554 www.cjcorner.com



A splash with colours

Art works created by 120 students are displayed at Kalaa Manjari Creativity Center - Global Art in Alwarpet. The annual art exhibition 'Hi Buddy 2026' showcases creativity, imagination and dedication to art. Families, friends and art enthusiasts are invited to view the display that is open till today. Visitors can also participate in the event casting votes, offline and online, for their favourite artworks. Kalaa Manjari is located at 2nd Street, East Abhiramapuram, Alwarpet, behind Nageshwara Rao Park.

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A data jam on March 28 will have participants studying how the Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai are faring on a set of parameters

LIFFY THOMAS

If data is a key factor for you to assess your constituency's performance then this event is for you. OpenCity, a civic tech platform that makes data easy to find, access, share and analyse is hosting a data jam on March 28 at Bhumi in Alwarpet to gauge how the city fared in parameters such as health, education, public transport, civic engagement and performance of the MLAs in the 20 Assembly constituencies in and around Chennai.

Data jam is not new to Chennai. OpenCity (a programme of the Oorvani Foundation) has in the past conducted similar workshops to study urban heat, lakes and flooding, and this one is planned to give participants a better understanding of the performance of the different constituencies ahead of the Assembly elections.

Here people from diverse professional backgrounds work in groups to understand how data can be used to understand civic issues plaguing the city.

Data available in the public domain is shared with participants and they analyse, brainstorm to get a better understanding of the issues and also give solutions.

For example, data from different databases and portals such as www.dge.tn.gov.in and UDISE will be used to get information on the number of government schools in an area, students enrolled and the count of teachers.

"Participants correlate to find what is lacking in every constituency," says Vaidya R., programme lead, Oorvani Foundation.

In 2024, the organisers used satellite data to understand ur-



A 'jamming' session ahead of TN elections

ban heat in different localities of Chennai. For instance, Koyamedu Metro was one of the hottest spots. In the part of Chennai it is located, Perungudi dumping ground topped the charts for extremely hot conditions.

The significance

"Either through maps put out by Greater Chennai Corporation or through their own experiences, participants correlated urban heat area," says Vaidya.



In some of the data jams, stakeholders take part in them or the findings are shared with them. The data jam on urban heat was presented to CMDA.

"A stakeholder could be a civic group working on the ground, and they could include the findings in petitions they submit to government departments," says Vaidya.

OpenCity has conducted data jams in all major metros and is happy these events offer people a platform to share their experiences. In Bangalore, a participant went on to develop a tool to measure the "public transport affinity" for a given area.

The data jam is being conducted in partnership with Citizen Consumer and Civic Action Group, Reach the Unreached and Nagariyal. For details, visit <https://forms.gle/cUIdseNvY-Yx4PWL78> or scan the QR code

'Data is a weapon'

Tambaram resident Raju K, working with a research agency, uses data to take up issues he feels strong about. In his mid-20s, Raju attended a data jam on lakes conducted by OpenCity; since then, he has been hugely curious about data jams.

A volunteer with Chennai Wetlands Action Collective and Save Madambakkam Lake Committee, Raju says OpenCity is a one-stop place to find data about a number of things.

For instance, for Save Madambakkam Lake Committee, they were able to get different data in the portal and use it in GIS maps and observe what the violations were.

"The data about the elevation of residential area, the lake and the real estate development next to the lake helped us get the real picture and petition various government authorities and seek action. We also found that as due to the difference in height, surface run-off water could not enter the lake and would inundate the existing residential area," he says.

Another example of using data is to analyse why certain areas get more inundated. "We studied 2015 inundation map and an earlier one to analyse Porur lake's catchment area. Urbanisation and SWDs not being interconnected were among reasons why inundation was common in this belt," he says.



Snapshots of a silent reading session.

Silent reading shifts to a new park

From Nageswara Rao park, which is closed for renovation, this initiative has shifted to a green space in RK Nagar, where it seems to have discovered a new home

PRINCE FREDERICK

Balaji Silent Reader @park. That is a digital contact card, an eyebrow-raising one clearly. It raised this writer's eyebrows when it popped up on his WhatsApp screen. It had been shared by K.L. Balasubramanian, a social entrepreneur driving RK Nagarra community developments, RK Nagarra being an association of residents groups in and around RK Nagar, the last outpost of Greater Chennai Corporation's Zone 13. KL Balasubramanian had reasons to save this contact this way.

It is obvious the number behind the card belongs to one Balaji, and as it appears, he is someone who knows how to keep his jaws locked while his eyes are scanning the pages of a book, and displays this behaviour at a park. What is not obvious is that he, Balaji Venkataraman, a resident of D'Silva Road in Mylapore, makes sure jaws not his own are also locked and that the nose above those jaws are buried in a book. He is the face of

the silent reading movement in these parts.

The silent reading movement in the Mylapore-Mandaveli-RA Puram area showed up first at Nageswara Rao Park around two years ago, with modest ambitions, when Balaji launched it along with other reading enthusiasts from the region. Before heading back into the genesis account, an update.

New space

This initiative has moved out of Nageswara Rao Park, and seems to set to get entrenched in one. Due to renovation work at Nageswara Park, the reading session became irregular. With

the Nageswara Rao park work gaining more surface area, it had to be shifted elsewhere. "On the Sunday of March 8, 2026 it went to a park at De Monte Colony on the suggestion of Vincent D'Souza, editor and publish-

er of Mylapore Times. And on March 15, it went to a park in RK Nagar, the one next to Ragamalika Apartments. And this Sunday (March 22), it will take place again at this park in RK Nagar," says Balaji.

And it seems set to continue with the newly discovered green patch in RK Nagar in the Sundays to follow.

Balaji observes, "The response last week at the park

in RK Nagar was great; around 30 people turned up."

Back to the genesis story at Nageswara Rao Park, participants' numbers swelled, the needle being pushed by two hands, curiosity and engagement.

Curiosity drew some feet, which stayed put when the value of what was being imparted to participants stood out. K.R. Jambunathan, a re-

sident of Kallukaran Street in Mylapore, is one such active participant.

Balaji notes that the exercise is aimed at people across age groups and though it has achieved this objective, children and senior citizens are a dominant presence at these Sunday sessions. Volunteers ensure books are at hand, the hat having been passed around to buy books; pre-read books make it to the collection as donation.

Though the one-hour, Sunday evening session is pledged to silence, it has to be broken for two reasons, one storytelling, handled by Bhavana; and two, snacks time. Volunteers pool in money to buy snacks for participants. Sometimes, snacks arrive from moremilagai.com, a catering service in Mylapore, promoted by Viji Ganesh.

(The silent reading session on March 22 is from 4 p.m. onwards at the park next to Ragamalika in RK Nagar.)

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Yoga workshop

Satyananda Yoga Centre of Satyam Yoga Trust is conducting a four-week Yoga programme from March 22 at the following venues: Sri Ayyappan & Sri Goshala Krishnan Temple, Sri Sastha Sangam, 89, Ponnambalam Salai, K.K.Nagar; Shri Sudarshan Terrace Hall, B-2, Lakshmi Nagar Main Road, Nanganallur; Sri Vengili Amman Temple, Madambakkam Main Road, Madambakkam; and Satyananda Yoga Centre, Murugu Nagar, Velachery. Classes will be held from 5.30 a.m. to 7 a.m.

According to a press release, no fee will be charged. The centre follows Bihar School of Yoga. Sessions on food habits and mantra recitation are part of the programme. For details, call 94450 51015.

Adapted volleyball tournament in Meenambakkam

Lit The Light Trust is conducting Louis Braille Trophy 2026, a state-level adapted volleyball tournament for the visually challenged, on March 29 at Indoor Stadium, Agur-

chand Manmull Jain College, Meenambakkam; 8 a.m. onwards.

The event is aimed at promoting inclusive sports and empowering visually challenged athletes. This is

the second edition of the tournament and at least 13 teams from across the State are expected to take part.

For details, call 98949 49878

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44/7, Lattice Bridge Road, Thiruvannamiyur, Chennai - 41
Land Mark - Near IMPCOPS, Behind Lattee Cafe